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Mr. Tom Fletcher, Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and
Emergency Relief Coordinator**

Security Council Briefing on the Humanitarian Situation in Afghanistan
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[AS DELIVERED]

Thank you, Mr. President,

Today I will focus on two issues: the humanitarian situation in Afghanistan and the application of the humanitarian exception provided through Security Council resolution 2615.

Afghanistan remains one of the world's largest and most complex humanitarian crises. Nearly half the country needs help, driven by insecurity, economic fragility, climate shocks, large-scale population movement and restrictions that hit women and girls the hardest.

You have heard that from my colleague Georgette Gagnon [Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Officer-in-Charge for the UN Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA)].

Mr. President,

In late February, fighting re-erupted between Afghanistan and Pakistan, displacing over 100,000 people across the eastern and southeastern regions and causing several hundred civilian casualties. Already struggling families were pushed even closer to the edge. Around 17,000 families in two districts in Nuristan Province who were already on WFP's [World Food Programme] famine watch list were cut off from all aid for almost two months. Damage to health facilities and schools disrupted services for tens of thousands.

While a ceasefire in April has led to a reduction in violence, explosive weapons contamination continues to pose a deadly threat – especially to children.

The conflict has also disrupted critical supply chains with the continued border closure affecting humanitarian programmes, especially food security and nutrition. A reopening of the border is urgently required to keep the response moving.

Mr. President, distinguished members of the council,

Hunger is growing across Afghanistan. Today, 4.7 million people are at risk of severe food insecurity, which is IPC [Integrated Food Security Phase Classification] Phase 4, which is 50 per cent higher than during the same time last year. Some 3.7 million children are facing acute malnutrition. We continue to receive alarming reports of families forced into desperate choices, including selling daughters, simply to survive.

At the same time cross-border returns continue. So far in 2026, 736,000 Afghans have returned, mostly from Pakistan, adding pressure on host communities and cities already struggling to provide basic services.

Natural hazards are adding another layer of suffering. Spring flooding has killed almost 100 people and destroyed or damaged tens of thousands of homes, alongside health facilities, schools, bridges, hundreds of kilometers of roads and vital crops.

The burden of this crisis is falling especially hard on women. Women-headed households in Afghanistan continue to face some of the highest levels of food insecurity and economic hardship, leaving many mothers to face impossible trade-offs about how to feed and protect their families.

Mr. President,

Activities supporting women and girls continue to be disproportionately affected by de facto authority restrictions, with at least six women's spaces closed in Herat Province since March and the suspension of livelihoods activities for women. Female staff have also been stopped in Herat for what the de-facto authorities claimed to be inappropriate dress, and over the weekend we have received reports of dozens of women arrested due to alleged non-compliance with existing strict dress codes, including women health workers. Afghan women

remain barred from UN premises. As you've heard, a ban that has now entered its tenth month.

These constraints are not abstract – they have direct consequences on our ability to reach people in need. Women and girls already face severe barriers in Afghanistan. They cannot attend school after the age of 12, they have limited opportunities for employment, and they face restricted access to basic services. When women humanitarian workers are allowed to do their jobs, more women and girls can get the support they need. When they are pushed out, their needs too often go unmet.

Mr. President,

Despite these obstacles, humanitarians continue to deliver. Between January and March, 4.9 million people were reached with at least one form of assistance under the Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan.

Let me turn to the humanitarian exception provided under resolution 2615. This marks the ninth briefing to the Council since the adoption of the resolution in December 2021.

The message today is clear: this exception is working. Life-saving humanitarian assistance continues to reach millions of people across Afghanistan.

The exception provides the clarity needed for the routine operational payments that make aid delivery possible. These include the everyday operational costs behind all responses: rent on state-owned premises, the withholding of taxes on NGO staff income, utilities such as water and electricity, as well as visas and work permits, security for UN compounds and movements, and other fees essential to delivering assistance, including imports, landing costs, licensing, communications equipment and municipal charges.

Since the adoption of resolution 2615, humanitarian organizations have seen real improvements in access to financial services for aid groups. The proportion of organizations reporting difficulties in transferring funds into and out of Afghanistan has fallen dramatically: from 87 per cent in October 2021 before the exception was secured to around 15 per cent as of May this year.

Our partners are reporting faster transfers and the re-engagement of correspondent banking relationships. Reliance on informal transfer mechanisms continues to

decline, with only 16 per cent of organizations reporting the use of hawala or other money service providers as of May 2026, down significantly from previous years.

Mr. President,

Even with this progress, we are still working in a very difficult environment. Bureaucratic and administrative obstacles continue to slow down aid delivery. Restrictions continue to affect humanitarian workers, especially as you heard again women. And humanitarian organizations face pressure to influence who receives aid and who gets contracts, along with the ongoing, of course, risk that aid may be diverted.

We take these risks seriously – and we manage them. Aid is delivered under strong monitoring and due diligence systems, limiting opportunities for malfeasance and ensuring that any concerns are promptly investigated and addressed. Post-distribution monitoring, verification processes, vetting and rescreening of financial service providers, and the establishment of inter-agency feedback and complaints mechanisms have all been implemented. If concerns arise, distributions are paused, any issues are addressed in consultation with all relevant stakeholders – including local authorities and donors. Operations only resume once clear compliance conditions are met.

An example of this thorough risk management process can be seen in allegations of potential aid diversion in Kunar Province including a cash-related activity. The partner was immediately notified and an additional round of post-distribution monitoring and inquiries were initiated to ascertain the claims. A review of beneficiaries found no evidence of fraud or diversion.

We take this very seriously. The collective and coordinated efforts of the Humanitarian Country Team to mitigate risks directly support the effective and responsible implementation of resolution 2615 – which is essential to the timely delivery of assistance in Afghanistan.

Mr. President,

Afghanistan's humanitarian crisis is not standing still. It is evolving – and, in several respects, deteriorating – under the combined pressures of rising needs, declining resources and restrictions on women.

The response is being severely constrained by underfunding. This year's response requires \$1.71 billion to reach 17.5 million people in Afghanistan. So far, we have received just 15 per cent of that funding.

The consequences are already being felt. Compared to last year, the reach of the response has fallen by 40 per cent, with 3 million fewer people assisted. Without urgent funding, WFP warns that famine-prevention activities for approximately 1.5 million people in high-risk areas will be cut. Support for families returning at several key border points is also at risk.

Mr. President,

I conclude with three requests of this Council:

First, continue supporting principled humanitarian action in Afghanistan, including through the full implementation of resolution 2615. Afghan civilians, again, especially women and girls, have suffered enough. They should not face further cuts due to the policies of the de- facto authorities.

Second, use your influence to press for the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure, and for humanitarians to be able to reach all people in need. Women humanitarian workers must be able to fully and safely do their jobs, and that women and girls must have access to life-saving support.

Third and final, urgently step up flexible and predictable funding. Without more support, we will be forced to cut back even further when people need us most.

I thank you.